A Very Clean Place

By Gale Mena and John Peat

SAMMY: Rock . . . *(Benji is moaning slightly, turned from the audience, gent/y rocking back and forth)* C'mon Benji, this is the fourth time today you've said you wanted to play . . . C'mon just say . . .

BENJI: Sciss . . . Sciss . . .

SAMMY: No Benji, we've been over this two gazillion times. If the name of the game is Rock, paper, scissors, then what comes next after rock?

BENJI: *(turns towards the audience, making his disability apparent)* Rock? *(Sammy sighs)* You hate playing with me, and so I hate you. A lot.

SAMMY: Benji, stop it. I can't do this every day with you. I have to go to school . . .

BENJI: You're leaving me again, you always have to go away, you like everyone else better than me, maybe I should just die because you hate me . . . Just go away. *(turns from audience, crying)*

SAMMY: No, c'mon don't say that. You know how that makes me feel. *(Benji wails)* You know what, forget about it. I'm going downstairs, I have to go to school.

BENJI: Sammy?

SAMMY: What?

BENJI: Can we play again? *(Benji is turned from the audience, humming and playing a make-believe game)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Sammy is just 10 years old, the baby of the family.*
ACTOR: *But developmentally she and her older brother Benji are not too far apart.*
ACTRESS: *You see, Benji was born with a genetic disorder.*
ACTOR: *This is their story.*
TOGETHER: *A Very Clean Place by Gale Mena and John Peat*

SAMMY: *(to audience)* What you have to understand is that Benji is almost seventeen. There's a seven-year difference between us.

BENJI: Sammy's stupid!

SAMMY: Occasionally.

BENJI: And Sam is a boy's name!

SAMMY: And lots of people like to name their dogs Benji, so what's your point?

BENJI: Woof! Woof! Woof!

SAMMY: Anyway, as I was saying Benji was first born. *(turns to see if Benji is indeed engrossed in his imagination so she can speak " privately")* Mom and Dad were alerted by their obstetrician that Benji was developing with an extra chromosome, which I'm not sure if you're aware but is a clinical sign of possible. . . *(lowers voice to a barely audible whisper)* Down syndrome. They were given two options, and they chose the one they were supposed to: Benjamin Sylus Szarsky.

BENJI: *(turning around, smiling)* That's me !! HEY, SAMMY!!!!!!!!! Is it my turn?

SAMMY: Go ahead.

BENJI: When Sammy was baby, she was stinky and I hated her cuz she was small. But now she is bigger and less stinky. And I don't hate her all the time too much. And I like to go to the very clean place with her. Do you guys like the very clean place?

SAMMY: Benji, they don't know what the very clean place is.

BENJI: Oh, well it is this place, that is very beautiful and very clean. Sammy and I go there a lot.

SAMMY: We live over beyond the ridge, and the creek is just down the hill outside our backyard. I can't remember a time when Benji and I didn't go down there . . .

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we catch tadpoles . . .

BENJI: I am a tadpoke! Look! Does his best tad-pole imitation.

SAMMY: Tadpole, Benji. TAD-POLE.

BENJI: I know, dumb-dumb. Tad-poke. Like this.

SAMMY: . . . And race paper boats and stuff like that. It's our favorite place to go.

BENJI: And it's very clean.

SAMMY: He's always said that. So, even though Benji has always been in the classes for special kids at school, it's never been easy for him. *(Scene break – Sammy comes to the quiet room at school. Benji it in a corner of the room, hitting himself in the face and head – she stops him.*

SAMMY: What happened this time, Benji?

BENJI: Jimmy . . . Jimmy told me all about the big machine that God has.

SAMMY: What? God doesn't have any big machine. Jimmy is just trying to . . .

BENJI: Yes he does. Yes he does! God has a very big machine and all of the people in all of the whole world pop out of [it]. And most of the time the big machine pops out good people who have good bodies and big healthy brains, but then . . . *(fades)* But then sometimes the machine gets stupid and it pops out stupid people with dumb heads. Like me. I got very mad at Jimmy! I told him that everybody is equal. That everybody is good and . . .

SAMMY: That everybody has a place. That's absolutely right, Benji. Everybody is perfect and . . .

BENJI: Just how they are supposed to be.

SAMMY: *(to the audience)* Sometimes it's like the tide, ya know? Ebbing in and out. How he can get so angry and out of control, and then, suddenly, he's just so spot-on. Like the wisest person in the world.

BENJI: *(singing)* Old MacDonald had a farm, eiei, o, and on that farm, he had some . . . poop. . . eieio

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SAMMY: *(to the audience)* Well, you know what I mean. Can I tell you guys a secret. . . ? I promised Benji I wouldn't, but . . . Benji is who he is, all the tough stuff, and all the wonderful stuff, it's like [he] was born with a "handle with care" label stamped on him, but recently he's been nervous and saying he feels sick all the time. There was a day at school . . . *(Benji is suddenly under the table, crying. Sammy bends down under the table)* Benji we talked about this, what happened?

BENJI: *(Out of control, screaming)* Nobody wants to play with me here I hate them, and I hate you for not being here with me! And I feel very sick, very, very sick in my tummy and in my big stupid head.

SAMMY: Benji, you gotta calm, down.

BENJI: Go away, You don't want to be with me.

SAMMY: I can't do this.

BENJI: *(pauses to consider this)* I feel sick Sammy. Really sick.

SAMMY: Is this so you can go home again? You've said you've been feeling sick a lot lately- B, if you don't wanna go to school anymore, then we should talk about it with Mom and Dad . . .

BENJI: Stop! The spinnies are back! *(covers his ears)*

SAMMY: *(standing up, addressing the teacher)* I need you to call 911. And then I need you to call my parents. Right now.

BENJI: *(to audience)* I have a secret that you cannot tell my sister. I am so scared.

(Scene break – Benji's family is at the hospital)

SAMMY: No one is ever happy at a hospital. It's where you go the get the bad news. The news that no one wants to hear, but when you do hear it, it's like a worm that's getting into your brain, you know, when the Doctor is saying, "It's very difficult for me to tell you folks this, but Benji has developed Leukemia."

BENJI: What is Leukemia? Is it a special treat?

SAMMY: No, Benj. Leukemia is a word that means, um, it means very sick.

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BENJI: Oh, I have been sick before. I will just take a lot of pills and it will go away.

SAMMY: It's not that kind of sickness, Benji. *(Scene break)*

SAMMY: *(to audience)* And so, the weeks passed, and . . . the options for Benji got to be fewer. One afternoon, just before he had to go back to the hospital, for the last time, we couldn't find him. But . . . I knew where he had gone. He had gone to the very clean place. *(Scene break)*

BENJI: *(Skipping rocks)* Does the creek go all the way to the ocean, Sammy?

SAMMY: *(She joins him in skipping rocks)* I'm not sure, big brother.

BENJI: That would be so fun to swim all the way to the ocean.

SAMMY: When did you get so good at skipping rocks?

BENJI: I was always better than you. That is because I am a boy and you are a girl and it is a sport. . . I don't want to have the bad sick.

SAMMY: I don't want you to have it either.

BENJI: I didn't understand dead until Aunt Bertha and then she was dead. She looked really creepy in that room. Like a big, fat doll. Aunt Bertha was fat.

SAMMY: Benji! *(reconsiders)* . . . Yeah, she was.

BENJI: I do not want to look like an ugly or creepy doll when I get dead.

SAMMY: Benji . . .

BENJI: Well, I do not. I already have a bad brain. I do not want to look ugly or creepy too . . . I am not that scared of dead. What I am scared of is not seeing you . . . Is it really dark when you get dead, Sammy?

SAMMY: I don't think so, Benji. I think it's going to be full of light. It will be the most beautiful, clean place you've ever been. With a creek and tadpoles, and a warm ocean.

BENJI: I need to tell you a very big secret, Sammy. Every night since I can remember, which is a very long time, I have prayed to God before I went to sleep that he would go back to the God Machine and make you a brother that wasn't stupid

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and dumb and got angry. You deserve a good brother. I am very sorry.

SAMMY: Benji, I have a secret too.

BENJI: You do? What is it?

SAMMY: I have a perfect brother. *(Benji looks confused)* His name is Benji. *(he smiles and points to himself)*

BENJI: I love you, Sammy. I don't want to go away.

SAMMY: We will always be together, Benji. Always and always. I promise. Maybe not our bodies, but, right here . . . *(she places their hands on each other's hearts -- Long pause)*

BENJI: I hope you get a boyfriend one day Sammy, before you get really old. And I hope he loves you as much as Dad loves Mom. And then, I hope you have kids that are perfect with big brains, like yours.

SAMMY: And when I do, I'm going to tell them stories about my hero. His name was Benji and he was . . . is, my big brother, and he was the most beautiful and perfect person I ever knew. I'm going to miss you so much, Benji.

BENJI: Please come here every day. This very clean place. Please make paper boats. *(Sammy nods)* and catch tad pokes *(Sammy nods again, holding back tears)* And please remember me when I get dead.

SAMMY: I will. **BENJI:** Rock . . . **SAMMY:** Paper . . . **BENJI:** Scissors . . .

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